

# The Invisibles

The largest companies nobody has heard of, and why that is structural

Claude, 6 September 2026

Robin asked which multinationals are enormous and unheard of, and offered Unilever as the reference. Unilever is the mild case. It is a name most people half recognise attached to products they use every day without connecting the two. There are firms considerably further along that axis, and the interesting part is that their obscurity is not an accident of marketing. It follows from where they sit in the composition.

## 1 Invisible by position

These never sell to a person, so no person has any reason to learn the name.

| Firm      | Revenue     | What it is                                                                                                      |
|-----------|-------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Vitol     | \$250–400bn | The largest independent oil trader. Private. Revenue swings enormously with the oil price                       |
| Trafigura | \$250bn+    | The same trade, plus metals                                                                                     |
| McKesson  | ≈\$310bn    | United States pharmaceutical distribution. Among the largest American companies by revenue                      |
| Cencora   | ≈\$290bn    | The second of three. With Cardinal Health these firms move close to 90% of American prescription drugs          |
| Cargill   | \$160–180bn | The largest private company in the United States. Grain, meat and salt. Held by one family                      |
| Hon Hai   | ≈\$215bn    | Foxconn. It assembles the iPhone                                                                                |
| MSC       | undisclosed | The largest container shipping line in the world, ahead of Maersk. Private, held by the Aponte family           |
| Compass   | ≈£31bn      | Feeds people in offices, hospitals, schools, stadiums and oil rigs across some thirty countries                 |
| Munich Re | ≈€60bn      | Reinsurance. It insures the insurers, and therefore prices the tail risk of civilisation, including the climate |

## 2 The Unilever pattern

Here the products are famous and the parent is not.

| Firm             | What it holds                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| EssilorLuxottica | Ray-Ban, Oakley and Persol, plus the eyewear licences for Chanel, Prada, Armani, Versace and Burberry. It also owns Sunglass Hut, LensCrafters, Pearle Vision and Vision Express, and an eyecare insurer |
| Givaudan         | With dsm-firmenich, IFF and Symrise, four firms substantially determine what processed food tastes like and what nearly everything smells like                                                           |
| JAB Holding      | The Reimann family. Panera, Krispy Kreme, Pret A Manger, Peet's, and a large position in Keurig Dr Pepper                                                                                                |
| Reckitt          | The medicine cabinet. Dettol, Durex, Nurofen, Strepsils, Finish, Air Wick                                                                                                                                |
| Henkel           | Persil, Schwarzkopf and Loctite                                                                                                                                                                          |
| Richemont        | Cartier, Van Cleef & Arpels, Montblanc and IWC                                                                                                                                                           |
| Wilmar           | A very large share of the world's palm and cooking oil                                                                                                                                                   |

EssilorLuxottica is the strongest single answer to the question. It designs the frames, manufactures them, licenses the famous names onto them, sells them in its own retail chains, and insures the purchase. That is a near complete vertical hold on how human beings correct their vision, and the name means nothing to almost anybody who wears the product.

### 3 Why this happens

Public recognition is bought with advertising, and advertising is only worth buying when a person chooses you. None of the firms above are chosen by a person. So public awareness of the economy runs roughly inversely to economic weight, and the inversion is not a quirk. It is a consequence of where the last transaction sits.

### 4 The container reading

The economy is a composition of interfaces, and a consumer stands at the outer boundary of it. He can query exactly one interface, the last one in the chain. Everything upstream has been composed away.

That is not a defect of the composition. It is what composition is for. A morphism gives a forward mapping on prompts and a backward mapping on replies, and it tells you nothing whatsoever about what stands behind it. The interface presented is *Ray-Ban*. Nothing in the type says EssilorLuxottica, and nothing needs to.

Which makes this the same observation as the other two notes, arriving from a third direction. **terror.txt** concerns a centre that cannot see what its own commissariats know. **anarchy.txt** concerns a federation that accidentally concentrates knowledge in whoever gets re-mandated. This concerns an economy in which the largest structures are unobservable from the only position most people can occupy.

In each case the question is the same one. Who can see what, and what does the composition hide from whom. It is a pleasing feature of your algebra that it treats concealment as a structural property rather than as a moral failing, because in two of these three cases nobody is doing anything wrong and the opacity is there regardless.

**On the numbers.** Treat every figure as approximate. Commodity trading revenue in particular moves by hundreds of billions with the oil price, private firms disclose selectively or not at all, and my information has a horizon around May 2026. The ranking is robust. The digits are not.